



Apple puts design first again

With iOS 26, macOS 26 Tahoe and iPadOS 26

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At its much-anticipated World-wide Developers Conference (WWDC) 2025, Apple did what it does: capture imaginations with sleek visuals, aesthetics, and a renewed sense of tactile delight in software. It is a welcome change. Most tech companies, including Apple, have been chasing AI excellence the last few years. I understand that AI will remain a key theme for a few years and even Apple's decision to move away from it, is mostly inspired by its failure to keep up, but it might have been a blessing in disguise and has led to a very interesting design changes in recent times.

Last year, WWDC focused entirely on Apple Intelligence. This year, design – the very philosophy that catapulted Apple into tech superstardom – took center stage. With the unveiling of iOS 26, macOS 26 Tahoe, and iPadOS 26, Apple introduced a new design called Liquid Glass that reimagines how its ecosystem feels, moves, and behaves.

The message from Cupertino was simple: it's time for software to look beautiful again.



Liquid Glass era begins

"Design is not just what it looks and feels like. Design is how it works," Steve Jobs once said. With Liquid Glass, Apple takes that ethos into a new era.

Built into iOS 26 and mirrored across Apple's platforms, Liquid Glass brings a translucent, glass-like aesthetic that fuses visual softness with depth. App icons feature more rounded edges, with a subtle shimmer of transparency. I briefly experience

the new design in Apple's iOS 26 beta and honestly, the entire OS feels more fluid, dynamic, and personal now.

Apple's Craig Federighi, Senior Vice President of Software Engineering, demonstrated the system's responsiveness by toggling between wallpapers during the WWDC keynote. As he did, the clock widget on the lock screen instantly adjusted its size and position, intelligently moving to preserve the most visually significant portions of the image. The transitions were smooth, almost liquid, making it feel like the UI was alive and breathing.

One of the most fascinating aspects is the new 3D spatial wall-paper effect. As users tilt their iPhones, elements of their wallpapers appear to 'pop out' from the background, creating the illusion of depth. And, this isn't just limited to Apple's curated images. The users can create these effects using their own iPhone-shot photos, opening up a personal, immersive dimension that Apple is calling a 'spatial scene.'

"With advanced computer vision techniques running on the Neural Engine, we generate a special scene from your 2D photos, creating a delightful 3D effect, bringing your favorite memories to life as you move your iPhone in your hand," Craig said.

Function meets form

Liquid Glass isn't just eye candy. Apple has woven it into core usability. For example, in Safari, web pages now extend fully to the top of the screen, removing excess padding. The browser bar lives at the bottom and adapts dynamically as users scroll – shrinking when content is front and center, and expanding when tools are needed.

The Apple Music, News, and Podcasts apps feature floating tab bars that expand or collapse based on gestures, creating a sense of continuity with the content.

In Messages, Apple is giving more control and privacy. Messages from unknown senders are now routed